Reshaping Rural Healthcare
Doctors at the Forefront



Rural India is the backbone of the country as more than 70% of our population resides in rural areas. Improving rural healthcare services with a focus on curative and preventive care has always remained one of India's development goals. The health status of people in rural areas is generally weaker than in urban areas. India's approach towards health care especially in rural areas has not only been constrained due to paucity of resources but also lacked the desired focus. Post-independence financial constraints have relegated rural healthcare to the lowest ladder of national priority. Health indicators show these observations. Over the last several years, the GOI through the National Health Mission, National Health Policy and Ayushman Bharat Mission, among other initiatives has improved the health of its population, narrowing the rural-urban and rich-poor divide. Central and state governments have been favoring appointments of doctors in the rural areas, some even making it compulsory to serve rural areas during their internship period. Young doctors are enthusiasts and willing to undertake a rural rotation early in their medical careers. This will help to identify those few who will provide leadership in improving rural services. India's economic growth is going up, rural infrastructure is improving, and it has access to technology, all of which have the potential to transform the health status of its rural populations. Few state governments have designed and implemented creative solutions to address the problems of access and affordability of healthcare. Several NGOs that work in difficult-to-reach rural areas have innovated to improve access, responsiveness, and quality of primary health care. In rural areas, the rural doctors provide a range of care, for a range of conditions to people across the life cycle.

Primary Health Center is the frontline contact point between the doctor and the rural community. The PHCs doctors provide accessible and affordable health care services to the rural population with special focus on vulnerable groups. Community Health Centres, a step up from PHCs, have at least four medical specialists i.e., surgeon, physician, gynecologist and pediatrician supported by 21 paramedical and other staff. It has 30 in-door beds with one OT, X-ray, labor room and laboratory facilities. The rural doctor's role is much broader and more challenging. Adequate knowledge and appropriate skills in supporting PHC at the community level are a prerequisite for a CHC doctor. The government through policies has been trying to bring equity in access to doctors, diagnostics and medicines for the rural population on a priority for the National Health Mission. National Rural Health Mission, launched in 2005, establishes a community-owned health delivery system through intersectoral convergence with a special focus on health determinants such as water, education, sanitation, nutrition and gender equality. NHRM's focus is on Reproductive, Maternal, Newborn, Child Health and Adolescent Services. Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHA) volunteers act as a bridge between the health center and the community. They are the first port of call for deprived sections such as women and children to access health services in rural areas. National Digital Health Mission, launched by PM Modi in 2020, is a complete digital health ecosystem. The mission aims to create an integrated healthcare system linking doctors with patients digitally by giving them access to real-time health records. The government's efforts to provide better healthcare to people in rural areas seem to have resulted in bringing the rural population into the formal healthcare infrastructure. The infant mortality rate, widely accepted as a crude indicator of the health scenario of a country has fallen quite sharply in rural areas, while the birth rate came down too. The death rate during this period declined as well. The latest data on live births, infant mortality and deaths suggests more people in rural areas are visiting doctors than ever before at private and government hospitals.

The government has advocated that basic healthcare facilities are much required for the progress of the urban, semi-urban and rural areas, then only the overall growth as a nation will be achieved. Some further steps are needed to be ensured like medical colleges need to encourage students to visit rural areas and understand the healthcare requirements of the poor and downtrodden. There should be more investment in rural areas through the Public-Private Partnerships to increase the last-mile reach of healthcare.